original form, it would have been difficult for the NDA to repeat its 2019 tally of 41 out of 48 seats. The BJP's vote share at the time was 28 per cent, while that of the MVA combine 57 per cent (Shiv Sena 24 per cent, Congress 17 per cent and NCP 16 per cent).

The MVA with Shiv Sena's Uddhav Thackeray as chief minister ran the state government for nearly three years before the BJP moved to strike two lethal blows. In June 2022, the party engineered a split in the Sena by pulling over Uddhav's right-hand man Eknath Shinde, and made him chief minister. Then, in July 2023, the BJP defanged the NCP by getting its legislative party chief Ajit Pawar to split the party and making him deputy chief minister in the Shinde government. To demoralise the Congress, the BJP recently got former Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan to defect by offering him a Rajya Sabha ticket. To drive the knife deeper into the Uddhav Sena, the BJP is roping in his cousin Raj Thackeray, and is likely to offer him the Mumbai South seat. The saffron party is now close to clinching an overall seat-sharing deal in the state that is likely to allow it to contest 31 seats (five more than in 2019), leaving the Shinde faction of the Sena with 13 and Ajit Pawar's NCP with four seats. Pollsters, however, say the BJP's machinations may have hurt the '*Maharashtrachi asmita*' (Maharashtra's pride), making the outcome uncertain in the state.

Even as it secured Maharashtra, the BJP was working to neutralise the threat in Bihar that had assumed dangerous proportions. In 2019, the BJP along with its NDA allies—the Janata Dal (United), or JD(U), and the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP)—had swept Bihar, winning 39 out of its 40 seats with more than 53 per cent of the votes. However, two years later, in August 2022, JD(U) stalwart and Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar walked out of the alliance with the BJP and formed a government with Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav. Nearly a year down the line, Nitish also became the fulcrum of the 27-party Opposition alliance with an imaginative acronym, I.N.D.I.A., or the Indian National Developmental and Inclusive Alliance. Nitish also made good on his promise of a caste census in the state, increased reservations on the basis of that exercise, handing the Opposition the poll

HOW 'RAM' CAN HELP NDA GO 'CHAR SAU PAAR'

In what he calls the BJP's 'Prabhu R.A.M.' strategy, political strategist and election analyst Amitabh Tiwari outlines how the party needs to Regain lost seats, Attain new ones and Maintain those it won in 2019 to realise Mission 400

REGAIN

- In 2019, the BJP lost 35 seats it had won in 2014 (*see table on right*)
- Of these, 20 seats are in UP and Bihar. While the BSP won 10 of them, eight seats went to the Congress
- However, this tally includes nine seats that other NDA partners won on account of re-allocation, including the five that went to JD(U)
- So, the BJP needs to regain the remaining 26 seats

STATE	SEATS
Uttar Pradesh	14
West Bengal	1
Jharkhand	2
Bihar	6
Andhra Pradesh	2
Maharashtra	2
Union territories	2
Rajasthan	1
Chhattisgarh	2
Tamil Nadu	1
Assam	1
Goa	1
TOTAL	**35**

ATTAIN

- There were 72 seats where the BJP was the runner-up in 2019
- A +5% swing in the BJP's favour and a -5% swing against the winner can help it win 39 such seats
- Adjusting for seats common in the 'regain' category, the BJP can attain up to 21 seats
- By contesting on 30-odd new seats in Maharashtra, Punjab and Tamil Nadu, it can look to win another five
- New allies like JD(S) and TDP can help the NDA corner another 20-odd seats, taking the attainable seats to 46

STATE	SEATS-1	SEATS-2
Assam	1	1
Chhattisgarh	2	2
Goa	1	1
Jharkhand	2	2
Karnataka	2	0
Manipur	1	1
Kerala	1	1
Maharashtra	2	1
Madhya Pradesh	1	1
Odisha	11	6
Punjab	1	0
Tamil Nadu	5	0
Telangana	2	1
Uttar Pradesh	16	8
West Bengal	22	12
Union territories	2	2
TOTAL	**72**	**39**

SEATS-1: Seats in which the BJP was the runner-up in 2019

SEATS-2: Seats the BJP can win with a 10 per cent swing